ties. Each block stadium, Suraj explained, will be constructed on eight to ten acres of land. It will be a complete package, including fields and courts for football, cricket, athletics, volleyball, kabaddi, kho kho and badminton, alongside indoor arenas for gymnastics, weightlifting and table tennis. The plan is to ensure the complexes remain usable year-round, with efficient drainage systems, lighting and access roads.

Going along with the new infrastructure is an emphasis on district-level talent mapping. By identifying which regions excel in particular sports, the state intends to direct resources more effectively. Some blocks may become football hubs, others could offer themselves as springboards for future athletes. Suraj described the philosophy thus: "This reflects our government's commitment to develop sports at the grassroots." Backing this up will be clear budgetary provisions for maintenance of new infrastructure, the availability of quality coaching, nutrition et al.

Takeaways

- **Stadiums to come up in all 314 blocks of the state. Outlay for five years: Rs 4,124 crore**
- **Each will have indoor arenas as well as outdoor courts/fields**
- **A parallel plan for district hubs and grassroots talent spotting to democratise sports in Odisha**

The idea is to generate a pipeline of talent at the grassroots, democratising the base of Odisha's sporting legacy. "These facilities are not just about infrastructure—they are about giving every young boy and girl, even in the remotest corners of the state, the opportunity to get trained, compete, and dream big. We want every village in Odisha to believe its children can achieve their dreams in the world of sports," says Suraj. The timing of this push is significant. With India nurturing ambitions of hosting the Olympics in 2036, Odisha is positioning itself as a crucial contributor to the country's sporting backbone. ■

▶ GUJARAT

Crash Course in CHAOS THEORY

A new online admission system throws Gujarat's college season out of gear, hits lakhs of students

By **Jumana Shah**

CAMPUSES ACROSS GUJARAT are caught in a sort of spacetime wobble. Over a month into academic season, admissions to undergraduate courses in state and aided universities have not concluded, even though the 12th board results came out in mid-May. Thousands of seats are still vacant, including in high-ranking colleges.

What's wobbly? A digital mechanism introduced by the higher education department: the Gujarat Centralised Admission System (GCAS). Over 365,000 students have registered on its portal. But by the end of 22 rounds conducted till the last week of July, only 56 per cent of the 471,000 undergraduate seats had been filled. Three additional rounds have been held since, but little progress has been made—due to technical glitches, poor process design and the usual snafus with coordination, server crashes et al.

This is the second year the government is attempting to introduce this system for admissions to undergraduate, postgraduate and PhD programmes across 15 state government universities and their affiliated colleges. Last year, after eight chaotic and futile rounds, the government had handed the process back to colleges. This year, they seem adamant on seeing it through. Thousands of panicked students, losing hope in the new-fangled system, have taken admission under the self-financed quota or opted for expensive private colleges.

The stated aim of GCAS is noble, of course: streamlining admissions so as to afford equal access and opportunities to students across the state, reducing the hassle and expenses they face in applying to each institute individually. It also promises to peg admissions to merit lists prepared automatically from candidates' academic qualifications, thus promising transparency.

NOT SO SIMPLE

But practical problems begin at the first step. Each student must indicate three colleges in their order of preference—and they get admission in all three, instead of just one, thus introducing a layer of complication. Students are frequently seen to be not confirming admissions as per their stated order. Educationists say this happens because, when filling up the form, they are often not aware the serial numbers strictly denote their order of preference.

The difficulty is more acute for rural students, who struggle with complex choices—with unfamiliar options spread out across